

Rococo

In reaction to the grandeur, chiaroscuro and drama of the Baroque, 18th-century art became more light-hearted and graceful, with soft colours, natural elements such as acanthus leaves, and elaborate curves and scrolls. Starting in France, and inspired by the indulgent court life of Louis XV, the movement lasted from c.1720–70 and applied to design, painting, literature, architecture, music and sculpture. It was later named the Rococo.

Jean-Antoine Watteau (1684–1721) painted elegantly dressed people relaxing in lush country surroundings. These frolicsome and idealized scenes became called *fêtes galantes* (courtly parties). Other Rococo subjects included mythological stories and portraits, painted with delicate brushwork and sensuous colouring. Rococo sculpture was notable for its intimate scale, naturalism and varied surface effects. Leading Rococo painters included Watteau, Giovanni Battista Tiepolo (1696–1770), François Boucher (1703–70), Jean-Honoré Fragonard (1732–1806), Chardin and Jean-Baptiste Greuze (1725–1805).



Boucher, *Diana Leaving her Bath*, 1742